

# The last ten yards

by Joshua · 2026-09-19

11,904 people killed in alcohol-impaired driving crashes in the United States in 2024 — down 3.9%, the third straight decline, and still 30% of everyone who died on a road.

Every service fails in the same place: the final gap between it and a person. The pharmacy is forty miles away. The bar is open until one and the last ride left at eleven. The lesson is on the board and the desk is the wrong height. The medicine is on the porch and the person who needs it is in the back bedroom.

Call it the last ten yards. Cities have mostly closed it, expensively, with density. The mountain West has not, because density is the one thing it does not have. Ten states — Washington, Oregon, Montana, Idaho, Wyoming, Colorado, Utah, Nevada, New Mexico, Arizona — where the distances are long, the towns are small, and the last ride home at closing time usually does not exist.

## Where it starts

[One line, in his own words, or nothing.]

It starts at a bar door at closing time. Not because that is the biggest market — it is not — but because it is the clearest one. Utah's own highway-safety office says its alcohol crashes happen Friday through Sunday between six in the evening and one in the morning, and that two-thirds of its DUI arrests are on the Wasatch Front, where the bars are. A car that is reliably at the door at one is not an app that might have a driver nearby. It is the last ten yards, closed.

## The order of the series

Why here. Closing time. The satellite that makes *reliably there* possible past the last cell tower. Who pays — the state, the venue, the rider — and why the answer picks the first county. A roof, a battery and sixteen garage bays. The first car, at \$41 a night. A measurement contract written before the first car rolls, so the number belongs to the state and not to me. Then medicine, because that is what is worth carrying this far. Then a school desk, because it is the same idea at a child's height. Then the lake, where the fleet's own telemetry lands and the loop closes.

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Sources: [NHTSA, Alcohol-Impaired Driving: 2024 Data](#) · [Utah Highway Safety Office, Impaired Driving Problem Identification FY24](#). Information, not advice. Every number is sourced or marked as an illustration.

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